

Content Quality Rubric

A Reusable Evaluation Tool for Closed-Platform, Justice-Involved Learner Content

Every other document in this set was built to design or audit one specific module. This one is built to outlive it. It's the tool a reviewer — including a non-instructional-design reviewer — would use to evaluate any content submitted for this platform and population, whether it's a partner submission, an internal build, or AI-generated content. The criteria come directly from what this project's audit surfaced, generalized into standards rather than left as one-off findings.

1. Scoring Scale

Every criterion below is scored on the same 1-4 scale, so scores are comparable across categories and across different pieces of content.

Score	Label	Descriptor
1	Not Met	The content works against the learner in this category — creates a barrier, risk, or harm that has to be fixed before publish.
2	Partially Met	The content mostly works but has a specific, identifiable gap that should be addressed before publish.
3	Met	The content meets the standard for this category. No changes required.
4	Exceeds	The content actively strengthens the learner experience in this category beyond what's required — worth flagging as a model for other content.

2. Criteria

A. Platform Independence

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
No external links or outbound navigation required to complete any task.		Any hyperlink, embedded URL, or instruction to "visit" or "search" an outside site.
No task depends on a tool or system not confirmed to exist on this platform.		References to journals, trackers, or submission tools — confirm these are in-platform or explicitly offline (e.g., pen and paper) rather than assumed.
Content functions the same regardless of device/hardware variance.		Fixed layouts, tap targets, and text that don't assume a specific screen size or touch sensitivity.

B. Learner Control & Pacing

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
No content is gated behind a forced wait with no visible way to proceed.		Locked videos, timers, or "complete X to unlock Y" mechanics with no skip or override.
Learner can repeat, revisit, or slow down without penalty or visible tracking.		Attempt counters, visible failure states, or any record of how long/how many tries a task took.

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
No comparative or competitive element.		Leaderboards, rankings, public scores, or anything that makes one learner's pace or performance visible to another.

C. Language & Tone

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
No stigmatizing, clinical, or institutional language.		Loaded phrases that assume deficit, hardship, or pathology as a given rather than a possibility — read every prompt as if the worst-case learner reading it has lived exactly what it assumes.
Instructions phrased as invitations, not commands.		All-caps directives, command-form imperatives with no stated alternative ("you must," "required to continue").
Reading level appropriate for a general adult audience (approx. 8th-9th grade).		Run representative copy through a readability check; flag anything that assumes prior specialized vocabulary.
No content assumes shared trauma, hardship, or requires personal disclosure.		Prompts that only work if the learner has experienced something specific, rather than working for any learner regardless of background.

D. Visual & Interaction Accessibility

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
No icon-only navigation.		Every icon paired with a text label; nothing communicated by symbol alone.
Sufficient color contrast between text/interactive elements and background.		Check against WCAG AA minimum contrast ratios, not just visual impression.
Generous, forgiving tap targets.		Assume the user may be operating a touchscreen for the first time — err toward larger, more separated targets.

E. Instructional Alignment

Criterion	Score (1-4)	What to Look For
Stated or inferable learning objective that the content actually delivers on.		Compare what the content claims or implies against what a learner can actually do after completing it.
Content chunked to manage cognitive load rather than presented as one continuous block.		Long lists or dense concept clusters broken into digestible, learner-controlled sections.

3. Worked Example — Original Module, Pre-Revision

Scored against "Discovering Your Narrative Voice" as it existed before the fixes documented in the Content Review Case Study. This demonstrates the rubric in use and shows how a numeric score translates directly into the same findings already documented elsewhere in this set.

Criterion	Score	Rationale
No external links required	1	Screens 5 and 8 both required outbound navigation to complete. See Case Study, Cases 2 and 4.
No forced-wait gates	1	Three video screens (2, 7, 10) locked with no skip control. See Case Study, Case 1, and Storyboard notes on Screen 10.
No stigmatizing language	1	"Do they come from a broken home?" prompt. See Case Study, Case 5.
Instructions as invitations, not commands	2	Most copy was neutral; the video prompt ("WATCH THE VIDEO TO CONTINUE") was the clear exception, not the norm across the module.
Icon + text label pairing	3	Confirmed consistent across all 14 screens even in the original version — no revision needed here.
Content chunked for cognitive load	3	Storytelling elements already split across two screens in the original — a design strength worth preserving, not a gap.

Average score across these six sampled criteria: 1.8 of 4 — reflecting real strengths in a few categories (chunking, icon labeling) alongside the specific, fixable failures the rest of this project addresses. The rubric doesn't just confirm what was already found — it shows the original module wasn't uniformly weak, which matters for giving accurate, non-inflated feedback to a partner or stakeholder.

4. How to Use This With Non-ID Stakeholders

- Share the score, not just the number — a "2 on Learner Control & Pacing, because the video can't be skipped" is something a partner without ID training can act on. A bare "2/4" is not.
- Anything scoring 1 should come with a specific fix, not just a flag — see the Content Review Case Study for the format this takes in practice.
- A 3 or 4 score is worth stating explicitly, not just skipped over — partners repeat what gets reinforced, and silence on what's working can read as "nothing here is worth keeping."